

Rushing to AI before solving the energy problem

Posted by u/Tulanian72 • 0 points • 21 comments

Each new generation of “AI” (sorry, but chatbots aren’t actual AI) is more power-intensive. It needs more resources. Given that renewables and non-carbon-based power sources are far from the main sources of electricity, the more AI data centers we build the worse climate change will get, and it’s already past the tipping point.

Seems to me like this is yet another instance of putting the cart before the horse. The same money and manpower dedicated to replacing fossil fuels with cleaner and more efficient power sources might have given the world the same rapid pace of improvement that we’ve seen with “AI” (we’ve gone from Siri to slightly-less-stupid Siri in no time flat). Maybe more efficient distribution schemes, maybe more efficient power storage, maybe more cost effective wind and solar, maybe safer fission reactors, maybe fusion generators.

If we solved the power problem first, and then used the more plentiful, cleaner power to run AI data centers, it seems to me that we’d be in a better place.

But we didn’t.

Comments

u/Deakljfokkk • 8 points • 2025-07-03 03:08 UTC

You posted just to bitch? Like what's the point of this post? Are we supposed to go fix it now?

u/GraceToSentience • 6 points • 2025-07-03 02:14 UTC

The fact that you start by showing everyone that you don't know what AI is tells me all that I need to know about this post

u/Fair_Horror • 2 points • 2025-07-03 01:17 UTC

This post feels less about power requirements and more of a statement that the tech doesn't work. Good luck with that lol.

u/Entire_Commission169 • 5 points • 2025-07-03 00:38 UTC

You can do more than 1 thing at once

u/simulated-souls • 11 points • 2025-07-03 00:28 UTC

> chatbots aren't actual AI

Look at [the Wikipedia page for AI](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Artificial_intelligence?wprov=sfla1).

Old-school Google search is AI. Chess bots are AI. Google Maps is AI. The YouTube recommendation algorithm is AI.

Chatbots are definitely AI.

u/whateverusername • 1 points • 2025-07-03 20:32 UTC

OP, on the other hand, isn't NI.

u/FailedWhistle75 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 00:13 UTC

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u/quoderatd2 • 1 points • 2025-07-02 22:34 UTC

With Great Power comes Great Externalities... The rate of progress has far exceeded our capability to regulate and mitigate the externalities.

u/jeff61813 • 6 points • 2025-07-02 22:00 UTC

We've already solved the energy problem. It's solar and wind but Mainly solar and battery, geothermal will probably be very important. It takes too long to build a nuclear reactor in at any time necessary to affect short-term electricity demand.

u/Tulanian72 • -1 points • 2025-07-02 22:11 UTC

The tech is only one variable. The political and economic framework has to be in place. In America most pols are beholden to the fossil fuel industry in some way. Hence all of the impediments to renewables in the budget being passed by the GOP.

u/jeff61813 • 4 points • 2025-07-02 22:17 UTC

I pay quite close attention to energy policy, it really doesn't matter what America does at the moment, The Chinese production of solar panels is completely changing the energy industry, solar is so cheap now. Doesn't make sense for people in the third world to buy a diesel generator to power their home it's better to buy Chinese solar with Chinese batteries. It's just the cheapest source of power now and economies that don't use the cheapest source of power or at a competitive disadvantage. Not to mention the fact you can throw up a solar power plant with batteries overnight but it takes 5 to 7 years to build an actual gas plant.

u/Tulanian72 • 1 points • 2025-07-02 22:19 UTC

Chinese tech dominating the sector could be part of why American conservatives hate it so much.

u/jeff61813 • 3 points • 2025-07-02 22:25 UTC

The United States was able to build 30 GW of production capacity in 2 years with the inflation reduction act, The US was well on its way to have its own independent production capacity, which will be handicapped by the the destruction of the inflation reduction act by the current budget bill on Congress. I can't give you rationale for these self-defeating non-economic decisions. But data centers powering AI almost all sign power purchase agreements with solar power companies to build purpose-built power plans since it's the cheapest form of energy most can purchase.

u/BoofLord5000 • 5 points • 2025-07-02 21:26 UTC

Most of them are already dumping billions into renewable and more efficient sources. Google for example has plans for a massive energy park using wind and solar. They've also have large investments into a few companies that deal with nuclear.

u/Tulanian72 • -5 points • 2025-07-02 21:34 UTC

Point being these chatbots are iterative progressions of the same "ask a question, get a stupid answer" technology. I've run tests using CoPilot and CharGPT 4.x on legal questions. Uniformly moronic.

We are spending untold billions of megawatts to enable faster stupidity.

u/Rain_On • 1 points • 2025-07-03 09:43 UTC

Could you give an example of such a question?

u/BoofLord5000 • 8 points • 2025-07-02 21:44 UTC

So what was the point of your post? These companies are already investing tons of money and research into better sources of energy. Are you saying more efficient sources = more intelligent models?

u/Tulanian72 • 0 points • 2025-07-02 22:13 UTC

The point is that the demand for power is scaling rapidly, and sustainable power sources are not.

We need a generational leap in power tech, akin to the Manhattan Project. The AI companies have invested more than Manhattan Project level resources into their chatbots, but nowhere close to that in power tech.

u/ThinkExtension2328 • 1 points • 2025-07-03 06:27 UTC

So how many watts of power is used by tick-tock and x and Snapchat and Facebook?

Why are these not a waste of energy in your eyes?

u/PwanaZana • 3 points • 2025-07-02 21:21 UTC

We'll build nuclear power plants.

u/Tulanian72 • -1 points • 2025-07-02 21:36 UTC

In other countries than the USA, quite possibly. Here in the States public sentiment is still very anti-nuclear. What was the last major fission power plant to get built?

u/farming-babies • 4 points • 2025-07-02 23:07 UTC

Look into the OKLO Air Force deal